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CYBER SECURITY INTERN

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# Phishing Email Detection & Awareness Report

Phishing Email Detection & Awareness Report of a public website (Read-only security analysis).

# Phishing Email Detection & Awareness Report

*Reviews suspicious email samples and phishing indicators.*

## Assessment Focus

Email legitimacy, phishing indicators, user risk awareness, and prevention guidance.

## Primary Methods

Sender review, link inspection, message context analysis, and header authentication checks.

## Overall Finding

Technically valid email signals do not always guarantee trustworthiness or legitimacy.

# Executive Overview

Phishing remains one of the most effective cyber threats because it manipulates human trust, urgency, curiosity, and ambition rather than relying only on technical exploitation. Attackers often disguise fraudulent or misleading emails as messages from trusted institutions, companies, or opportunity providers in order to collect personal information, credentials, or financial details.

This report evaluates three email samples and classifies their risk by examining sender credibility, greeting style, destination links, technical authentication, and social engineering patterns. The final sections convert these findings into practical guidance for users and employees.

## Core Review Areas

- Sender Authenticity
- Link Safety
- Header Analysis
- Social Engineering
- Risk Classification
- User Awareness

# Email Analysis

## Email 1: Adobe Internship Scam

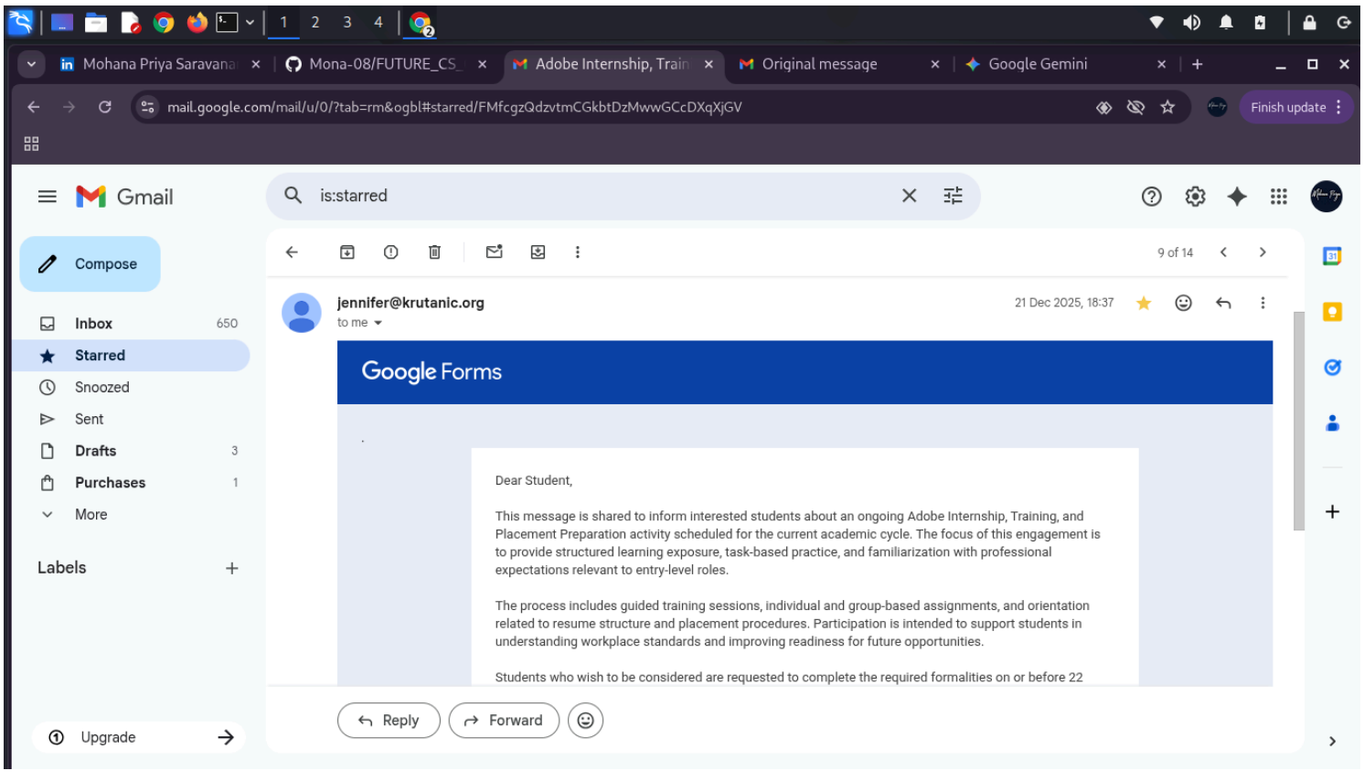
**Suspicious / Potential Phishing**

**Subject:** Adobe Internship, Training and Placement Preparation – Academic Schedule Update

**Sender:** jennifer@krutanic.org

**Status:** Suspicious / Potential Phishing

**Description:** This email presents itself as an Adobe internship-related opportunity and instructs students to complete a form before a deadline. The message uses a recognizable company name to gain trust while encouraging quick action.

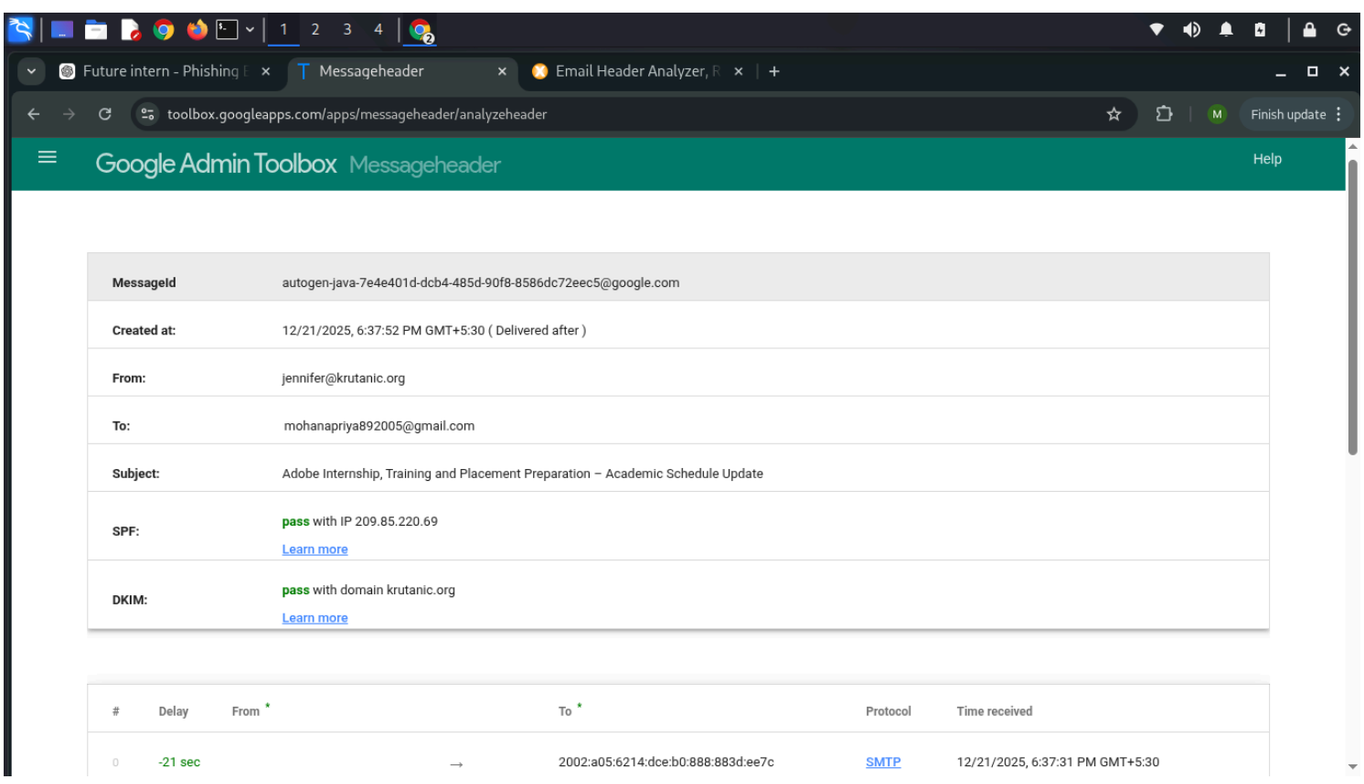



**Phishing Indicators:**

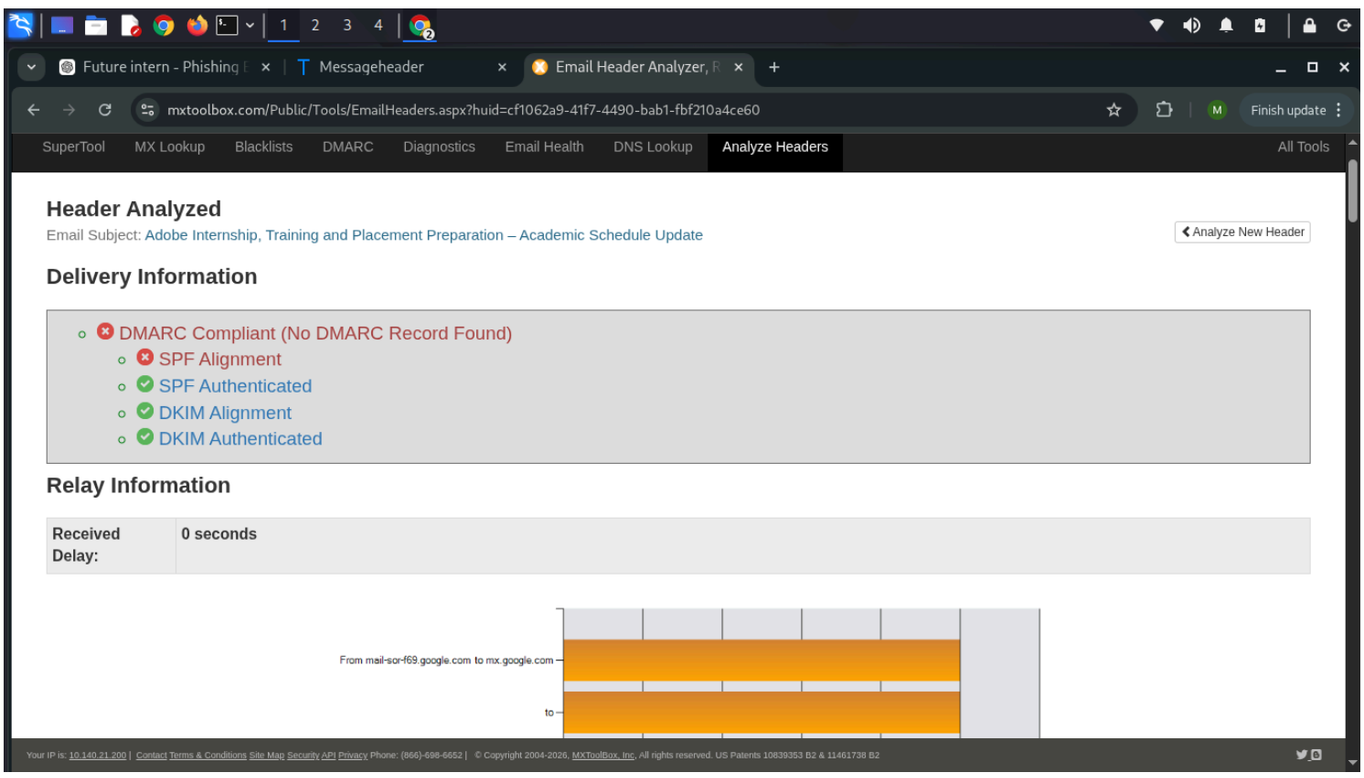
- Sender domain is not an official Adobe domain
- Uses a generic greeting such as Dear Student
- Creates deadline pressure to trigger immediate action
- Leverages the Adobe brand to appear credible
- Uses Google Forms instead of an official website

**Link Review:**

- Redirects to a Google Form
- Does not verify any official Adobe affiliation
- Destination is not hosted on a corporate domain



| Header Check | Result | Interpretation |
|---|---|---|
| SPF | Pass | Domain is allowed to send for itself |
| DKIM | Pass | Message signing is technically valid |
| DMARC | Not configured | Reduced anti-spoofing assurance |
| SPF alignment | Issue detected | Passing authentication does not confirm Adobe legitimacy |




**Assessment:** Authentication passed only for the sender's domain and does not prove any connection to Adobe. The off-brand domain, generic greeting, and Google Form-based data collection make this email suspicious.

**Tags:** Authority Impersonation | Urgency | Opportunity Lure

## Email 2: Aptitude Platform Promotion

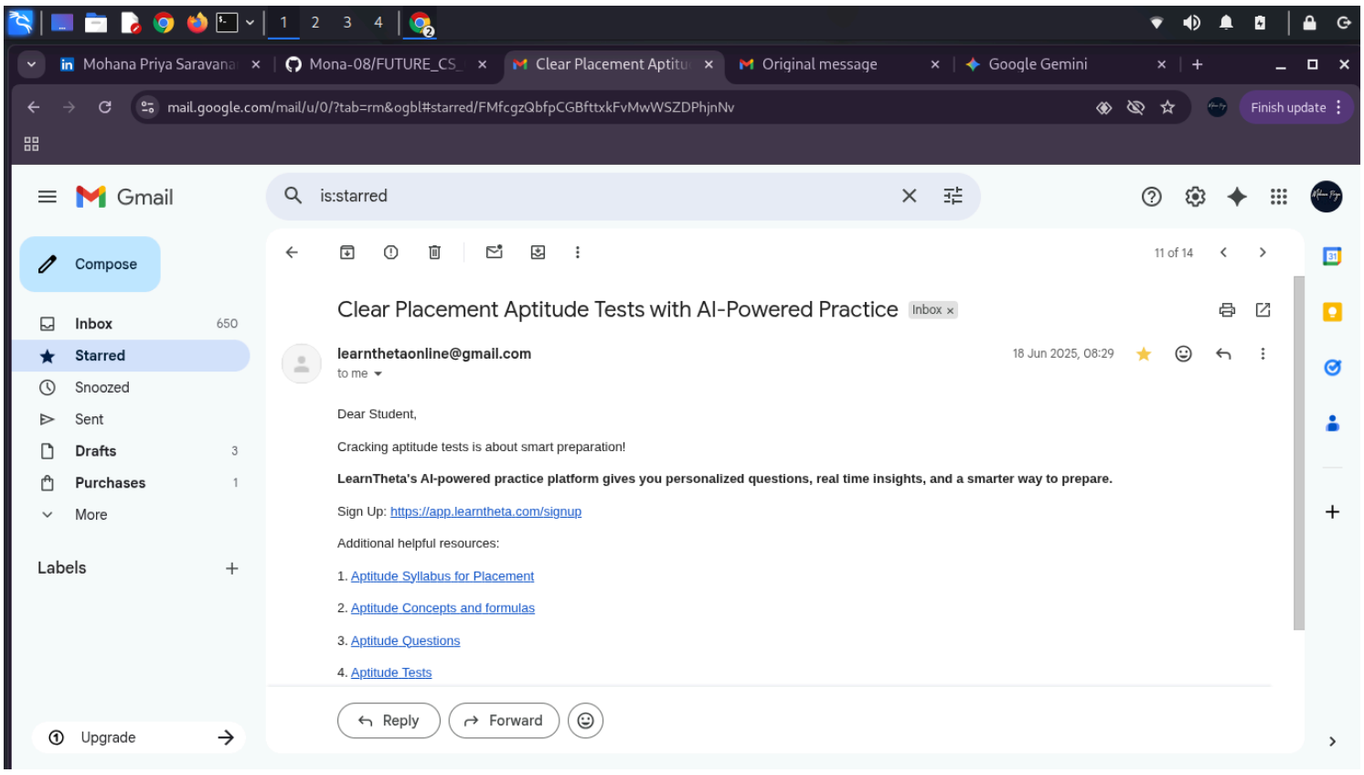
**Suspicious / Promotional**

**Subject:** Clear Placement Aptitude Tests with AI-Powered Practice

**Sender:** learnthetaonline@gmail.com

**Status:** Suspicious / Promotional

**Description:** This email promotes an AI-based aptitude preparation platform and encourages users to sign up. Although the email appears technically authenticated, the sender identity and organizational legitimacy are not strongly established.

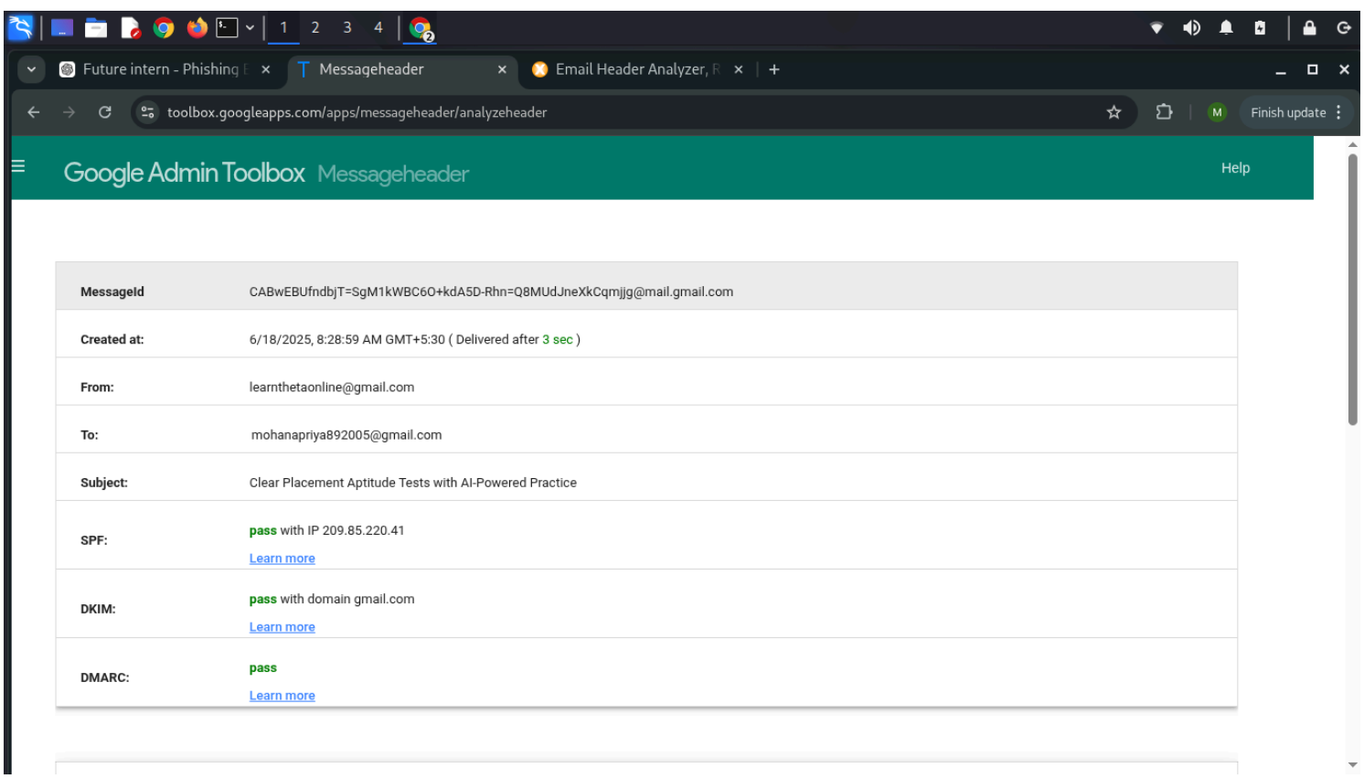



**Observed Indicators:**

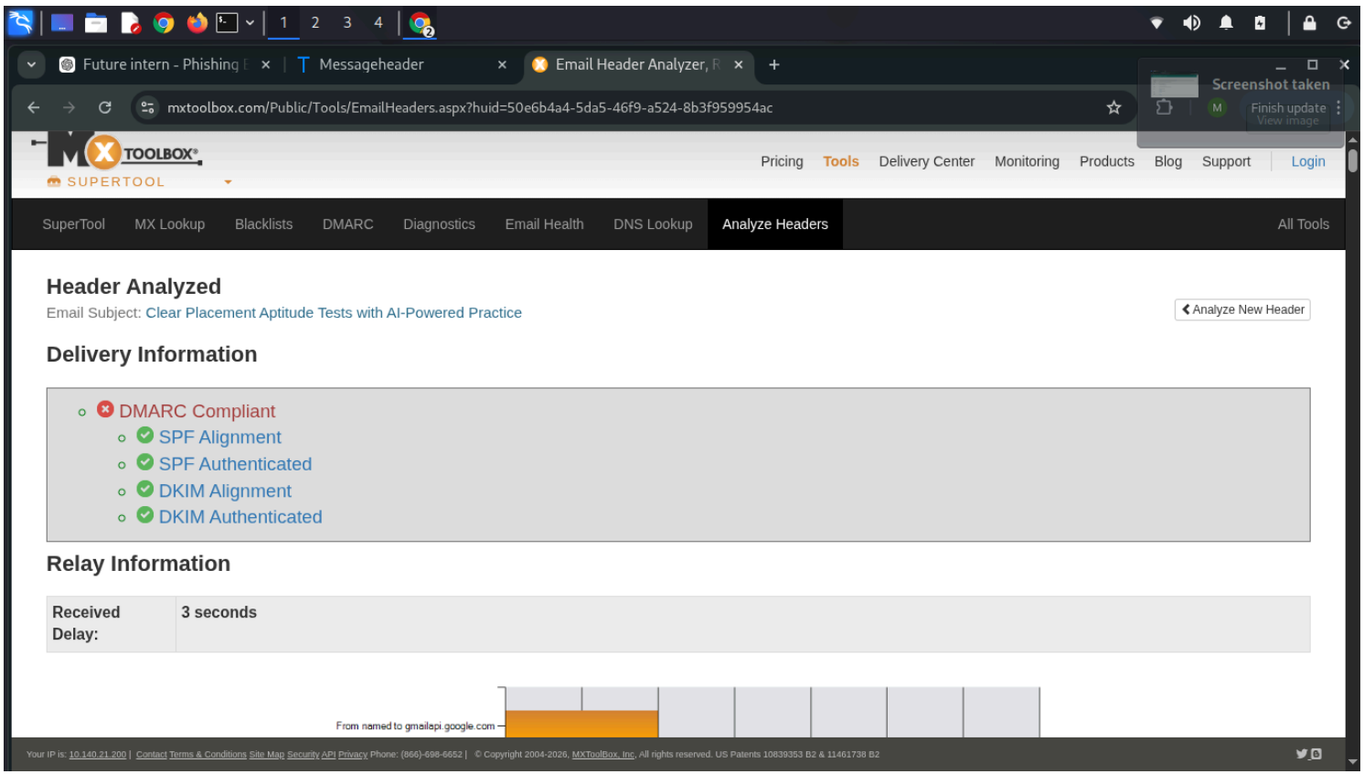
- Uses a generic greeting
- Comes from a public Gmail address instead of a corporate domain
- No strong company verification is provided
- Message tone is promotional and persuasive

**Link Review:**

- Uses HTTPS, which secures transport but does not guarantee trust
- Domain appears functional but is not independently verified in this analysis
- Users should validate ownership before entering data



| Header Check | Result | Interpretation |
|---|---|---|
| SPF | Pass | Sending source is permitted |
| DKIM | Pass | Email signature validation succeeded |
| DMARC | Pass | Domain-level policy exists and passed |




**Assessment:** This email does not show obvious spoofing at the protocol level, but technical validity alone is not proof of credibility. The public sender address and unclear company verification justify a cautious, suspicious classification.

**Tags:** Career Motivation | Curiosity | Soft Persuasion

## Email 3: Placement Program Registration Scam

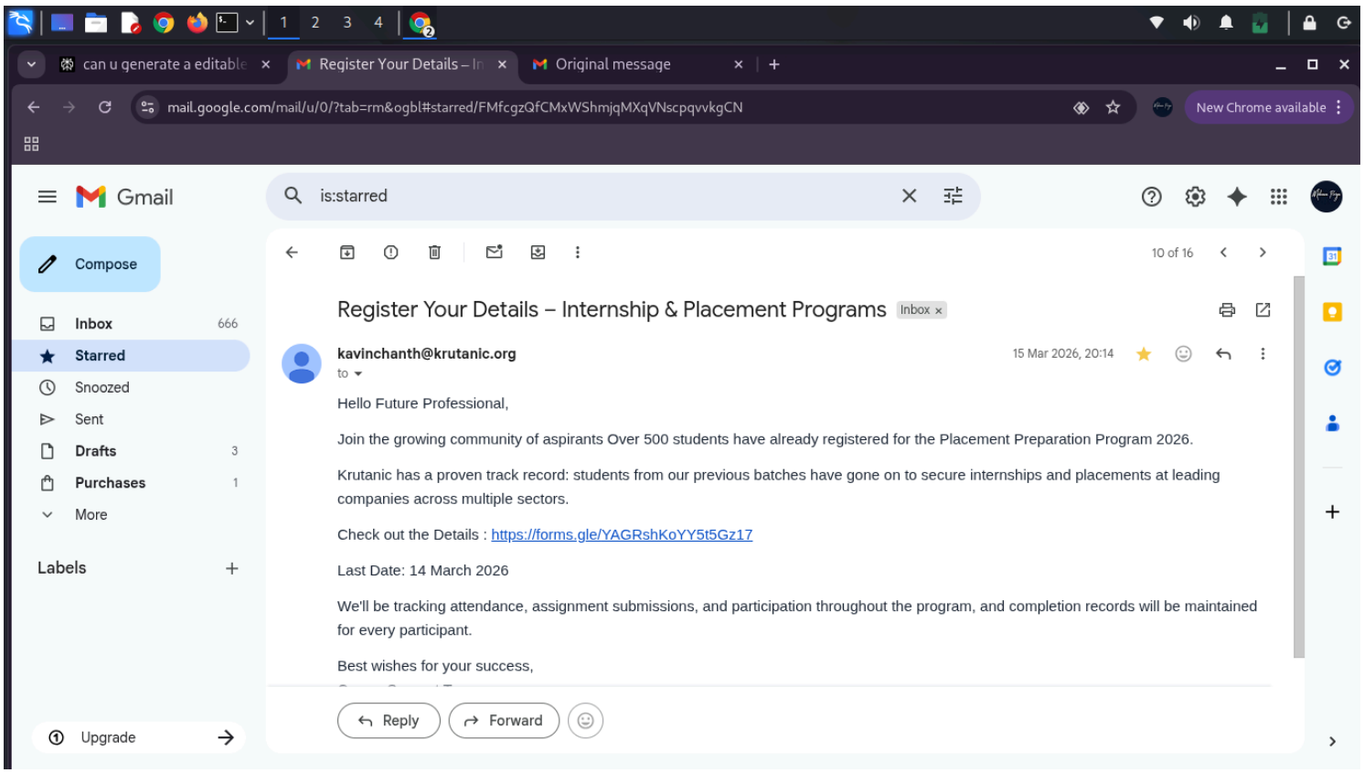
Phishing

**Subject:** Register Your Details – Internship & Placement Programs

**Sender:** kavinchanth@krutanic.org

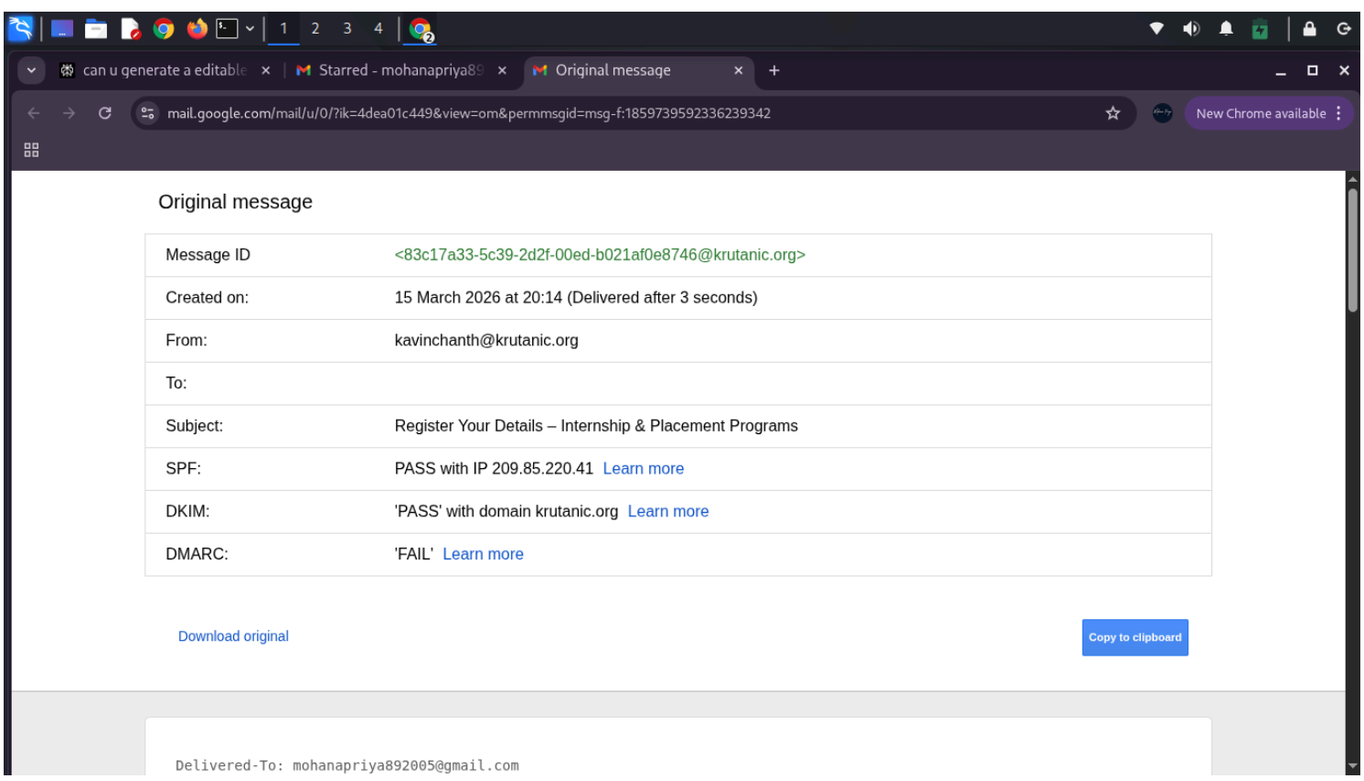
**Status:** Phishing

**Description:** This message invites recipients to join internship and placement programs by submitting their details through a Google Form. Multiple warning signs suggest that the email is designed to collect user information by creating false trust and artificial legitimacy.



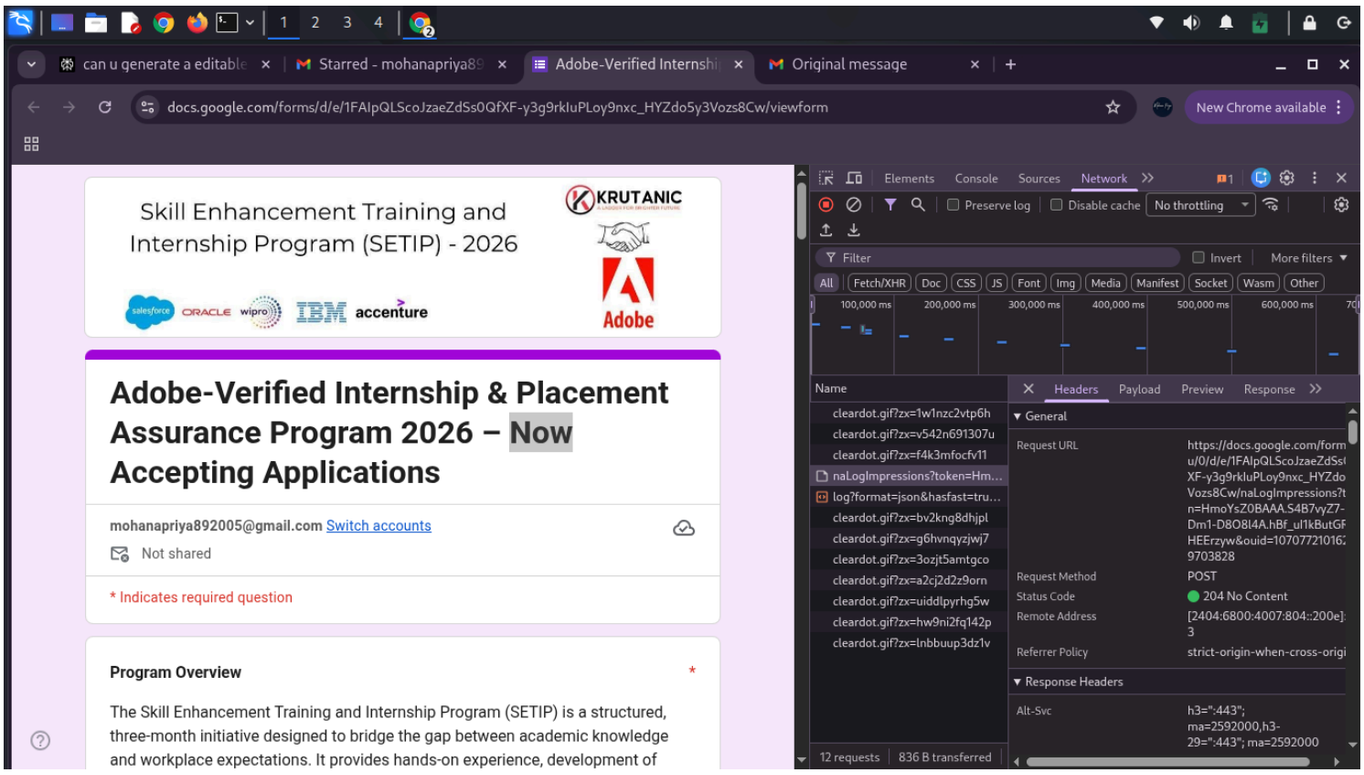

**Phishing Indicators:**

- Uses a generic greeting such as Hello Future Professional
- Applies social proof by claiming that many students have registered
- Uses Google Forms instead of an official portal
- Mentions an expired deadline, which reduces credibility
- Provides no verified company identity

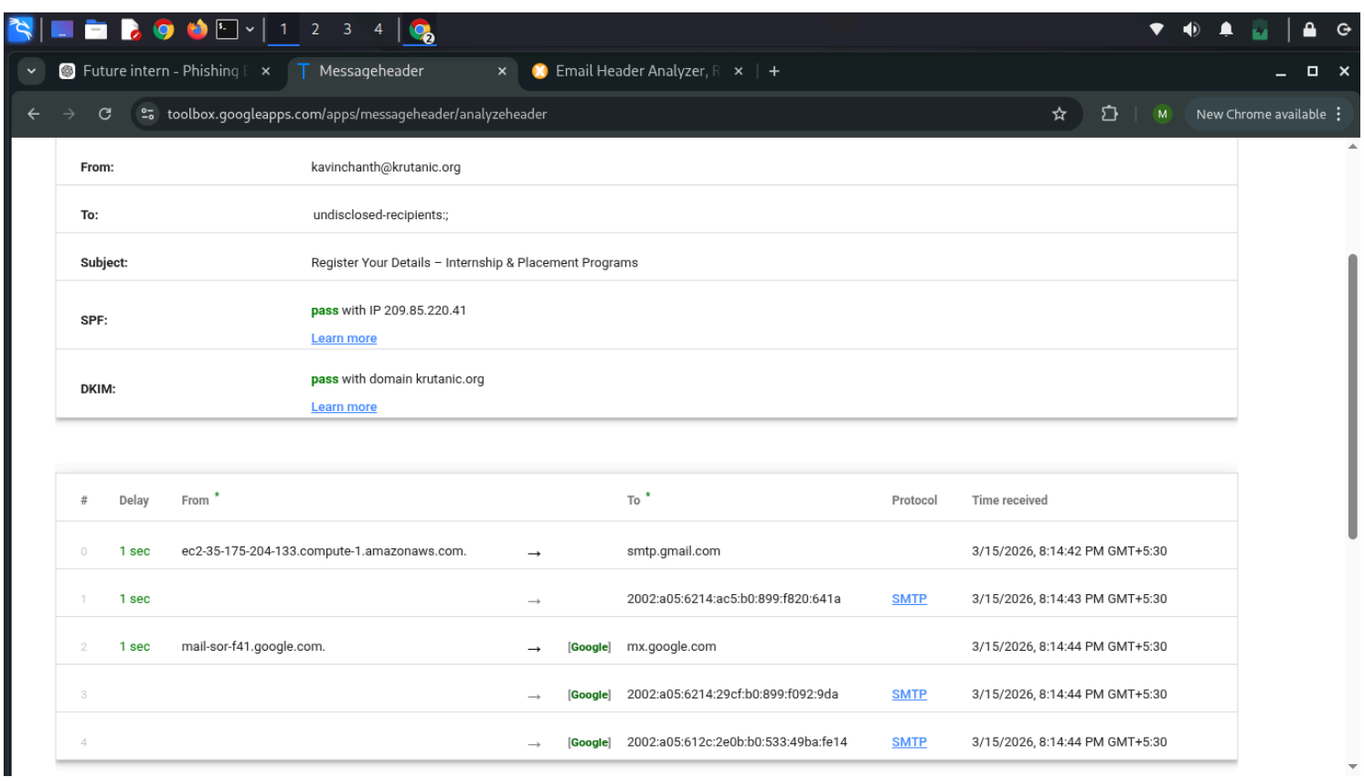



**Link Review:**

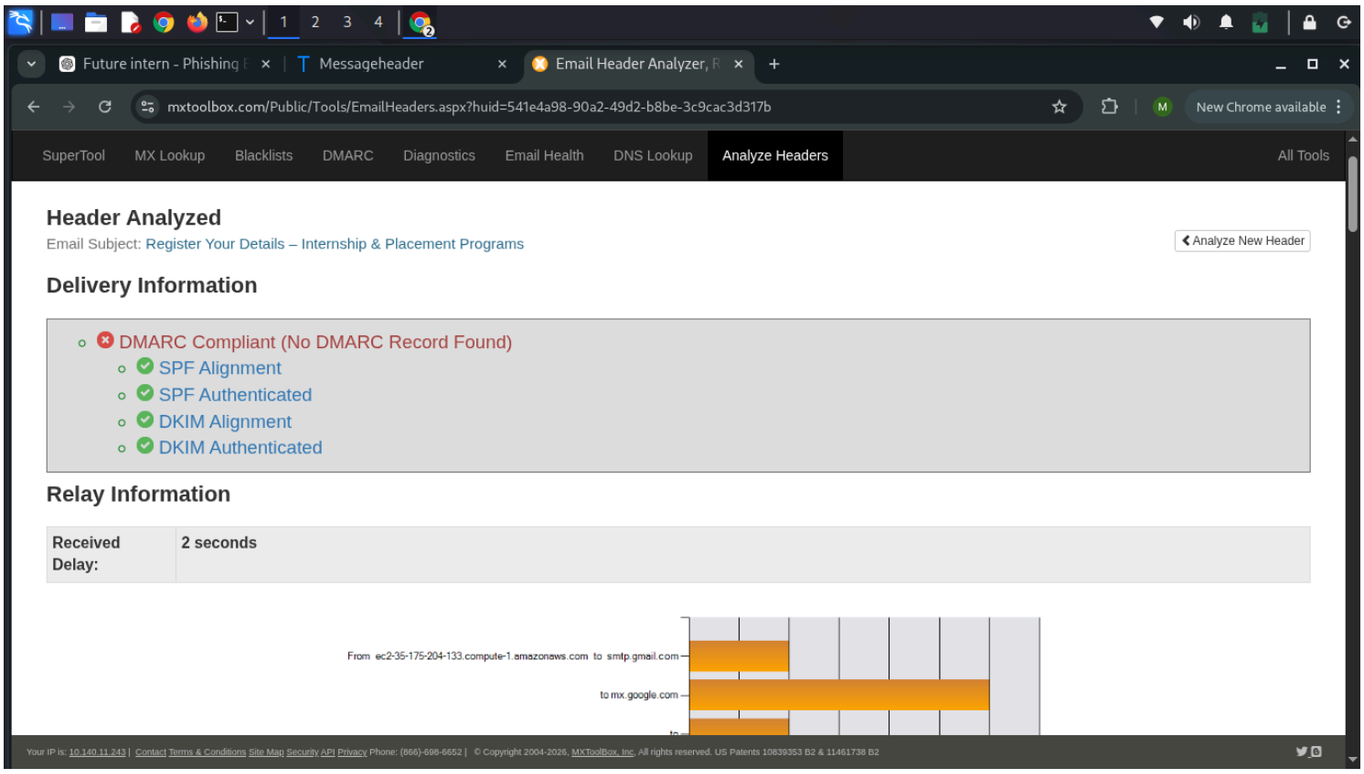
- Google Forms is a legitimate platform frequently abused for fraudulent collection
- Destination is not tied to a trusted corporate domain
- Likely intended to gather user-submitted personal information




| Header Check | Result | Interpretation |
|---|---|---|
| SPF | Pass | Sender domain is permitted to send |
| DKIM | Pass | Message signing is valid for the sending domain |
| DMARC | Not configured | Weakens domain trust and spoofing protection |
| Infrastructure | AWS server | Suggests non-corporate bulk-sending environment |



**Assessment:** When missing DMARC, generic wording, social proof, and third-party form-based data collection are considered together, the overall pattern aligns strongly with phishing behavior.




**Tags:** Social Proof | Authority Illusion | Opportunity Lure

| Email Sample | Main Concern | Authentication Status | Overall Classification |
|---|---|---|---|
| Adobe Internship Scam | Brand impersonation and off-domain form submission | SPF/DKIM pass, DMARC missing | Suspicious (Potential Phishing) |
| Aptitude Platform Promotion | Unverified promotional outreach | SPF/DKIM/DMARC pass | Suspicious / Promotional |
| Placement Program Registration Scam | Third-party data capture with manipulative trust signals | SPF/DKIM pass, DMARC missing | Phishing |

## How Phishing Attacks Work

Phishing attacks typically imitate trusted organizations and push users to click links, open attachments, or submit sensitive information. In most cases, the attack is successful because it exploits human behavior, attention, and emotion rather than a direct technical vulnerability.

Attackers often rely on urgency, trust, fear, curiosity, or career-related motivation to influence user decisions. Once the victim responds, the attacker may obtain credentials, personal data, financial information, or future targeting opportunities.

## Recommended Actions

- Verify the sender's full email address carefully
- Hover over links before clicking
- Use official websites directly for login or registration
- Report suspicious messages to the appropriate authority or security team
- Check wording, grammar, and unusual requests before responding

## Actions to Avoid

- Do not click unknown or unverified links
- Do not share passwords, OTPs, or personal information through forms
- Do not trust messages only because they sound urgent or official
- Do not submit data on third-party forms unless the source is confirmed
- Do not assume SPF or DKIM alone proves legitimacy

## Employee Awareness Guidance

Users should be especially cautious of messages that promise internships, placement support, urgent updates, rewards, or unexpected opportunities. Even when a message appears technically valid, sender identity, destination links, tone, and context should always be reviewed before taking action.

Organizations can reduce phishing success by reinforcing awareness training, encouraging independent verification, and promoting a habit of slowing down before responding to emotionally persuasive requests.

## Tools Used

- Google Message Header Analyzer
- MXToolbox Header Analyzer
- Web Browser for Link Inspection

## Conclusion

This report shows that phishing detection requires a combination of technical review and careful human judgment. Some messages may pass SPF or DKIM while still using misleading branding, vague identity, unsafe links, or manipulative social engineering methods.

The strongest defense against phishing is disciplined verification. Users who inspect, pause, and confirm legitimacy through official channels are much less likely to become victims of deceptive email campaigns.

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# Phishing: Don't get caught in the net

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Mohana Priya

Thank You for your solely reading